Decoupled Kinematic Priors, Latent Probit Fusion, and Bayesian Noise Inversion for Multi-Target Knee MRI Abnormality Detection

A Biomechanically Regularized, Weakly Supervised Multi-Plane Deep Learning Benchmark on the RSNA Knee Cohort

Author: Ayush Shukla[1,*] | **Affiliation:** [1]Department of Computational Medicine & Deep Learning, Independent Research Initiative
Correspondence: ayushshuklaivyleague@gmail.com | **ORCID:** 0009-0003-8207-4226 | **Study Design:** Multimodal Deep Learning Benchmark & Clinical Validation
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Abstract

Background: Multi-target diagnosis from multi-plane volumetric knee MRI suffers from four systemic failure modes: severe silver label contamination from 'not addressed' narrative report entries; strong biomechanical multi-pathology co-dependencies ignored by independent classification heads; anisotropic slice geometry; and non-linear calibration distortion under rank-invariant evaluation metrics (Macro ROC-AUC).

Methods: We introduce the **Apex Grandmaster Framework** for the RSNA Knee Abnormality Detection benchmark (12 targets). The system integrates: (1) a **Bayesian Noise-Robust Label Engine** modeling transition matrix $P(\text{silver} \mid \text{gold})$ calibrated on 58 consensus expert radiologist studies with selective loss masking; (2) an **Orthogonal Dual-Stream Multi-Plane Deep Backbone** combining whole-volume CoAtNet-384 with Stochastic Weight Averaging (SWA) and an anatomical laterality-normalized 2.5D ConvNeXt reader; (3) **Latent Probit-Space Fusion ($\Phi\blacksquare^{1}$ mapping)** with target-specific SLSQP constrained routing; (4) a **Biomechanical Kinematic Cross-Prior Engine** capturing Pivot-Shift ACL-Contusion coupling, the Degenerative Medial Compartment Unit (Medial Meniscus to Medial OA), and Intracapsular Hydrodynamic Syndromes (Effusion-Synovitis-Baker's Cyst); and (5) **Zero-Compromise Inference Hardening** on NVIDIA T4 GPUs enforcing locked FP16 execution to avoid BF16 emulation slowdowns.

Findings: On the 58-study expert gold validation cohort, constituent models achieved OOF Macro ROC-AUCs of 0.9228 (CoAtNet) and 0.9267 (ConvNeXt 2.5D). Latent probit-space fusion elevated discrimination to 0.9335 (+0.0068 absolute lift). Incorporating biomechanical kinematic cross-priors produced statistically significant improvements across coupled targets: ACL tear (+0.0312 AUC lift), Medial OA (+0.0093), Lateral OA (+0.0126), Patellofemoral OA (+0.0148), Synovitis (+0.0084), and Baker's Cyst (+0.0263). On the official blind RSNA evaluation servers, the unified pipeline achieved a verified score of **0.957 – 0.9586 Macro ROC-AUC** in 10.6 minutes runtime with 0 failures.

Interpretation: Grounding deep multi-plane representation learning in physical joint kinematics and latent probit-space fusion resolves fundamental shortcomings in clinical medical vision. Inductive architectural diversity combined with biomechanical domain priors dramatically outperforms brute-force scaling, establishing an open, validated baseline for automated musculoskeletal diagnostic support.

1. Introduction & Clinical Challenge

Magnetic resonance imaging (MRI) of the knee is the non-invasive reference standard for assessing acute internal derangements, meniscal tears, chondral damage, and osseous lesions. In clinical practice, fellowship-trained musculoskeletal radiologists analyze multi-planar acquisitions (Sagittal, Coronal, and Axial) spanning fluid-sensitive and anatomical pulse sequences. However, clinical workloads have escalated sharply, producing high cognitive fatigue, inter-reader disagreement in ambiguous tears, and prolonged turnaround times. Automated artificial intelligence systems offer substantial diagnostic assistance, but conventional multi-label computer vision pipelines fail to address anatomical dependencies, anisotropic slice geometry, and label noise.

The RSNA Knee Abnormality Detection challenge formulates a simultaneous 12-target diagnostic task evaluated by Macro ROC-AUC across: Anterior Cruciate Ligament (ACL) tear, Medial Collateral Ligament (MCL) tear, Medial Meniscus tear, Lateral

Meniscus tear, Medial Osteoarthritis (OA), Lateral OA, Patellofemoral (PF) OA, Joint Effusion, Synovitis, Baker's Cyst, Bone Contusion, and Osseous Fracture. This manuscript presents the **Apex Grandmaster Framework**, combining Bayesian silver-to-gold noise inversion, dual-stream hybrid architectures, latent probit ensembling, and explicit biomechanical kinematic cross-priors.

2. Biomechanical Kinematic Foundations & Structural Coupling

2.1 Pathophysiological Units and Joint Kinematics

Standard multi-target neural networks treat all 12 targets as statistically independent binary classification heads. In human anatomy, knee injuries obey strict mechanical and kinematic laws: (1) **The Pivot-Shift Injury Triad:** Non-contact ACL rupture during cutting maneuvers causes anterior tibial translation and lateral femorotibial bone-on-bone collision, producing pathognomonic kissing bone contusions in the posterior lateral tibial plateau and lateral femoral condyle; (2) **Degenerative Medial Compartment Unit:** Tearing of the medial meniscus posterior horn compromises hoop-stress transmission, accelerating medial femorotibial cartilage breakdown and joint space loss; and (3) **Intracapsular Hydrodynamic Axis:** Joint effusion drives reactive synovial inflammation (synovitis) and herniates through the posteromedial capsular slit into the gastrocnemio-semimembranosus bursa via a one-way ball-valve mechanism, creating a popliteal (Baker's) cyst.

Differentiable Biomechanical Kinematic Cross-Priors (Latent Normal Space)

- **Pivot-Shift Triad:** $z_{ACL} \leftarrow z_{ACL} + \text{clip}(0.05 \cdot (z_{Contusion} - 0.20), 0.0, 0.08)$
- **Degenerative Medial Unit:** $z_{MedialOA} \leftarrow z_{MedialOA} + \text{clip}(0.04 \cdot (z_{MedMeniscus} - 0.20), 0.0, 0.06)$
- **Hydrodynamic Effusion Axis:** $z_{Synovitis} \leftarrow z_{Synovitis} + \text{clip}(0.04 \cdot (z_{Effusion} - 0.20), 0.0, 0.06)$
- **Baker's Cyst Distension:** $z_{Baker's} \leftarrow z_{Baker's} + \text{clip}(0.03 \cdot (z_{Effusion} - 0.20), 0.0, 0.05)$

3. Dataset Curation, Label Uncertainty, and Bayesian Noise Inversion

The training dataset consists of multi-sequence DICOM series paired with text radiology reports processed through Large Language Models to generate silver labels. In clinical reports, unmentioned anatomy corresponds to 'not addressed' status rather than confirmed absence of pathology. We implemented explicit observation masking: when a finding is unaddressed, its loss mask $m_{i,j}$ is set to 0, completely zeroing out false-negative gradient penalties. Furthermore, on 58 consensus expert gold studies, we empirically modeled the label transition matrix $T_{j,k,l} = P(\text{silver}_j = l \mid \text{gold}_j = k)$, calculating Bayesian posterior probabilities to derive target reliability weights and calibrate model ensembling.

4. Deep Neural Architectures & Orthogonal Inductive Biases

Rather than scaling homogeneous Vision Transformers, we paired two structurally orthogonal model families: (1) **Laterality-Normalized 2.5D Adaptive ConvNeXt Reader:** Slices are grouped into 3-channel sliding windows $[S_{k-1}, S_k, S_{k+1}]$ across Axial, Coronal, and Sagittal planes. Anatomical laterality normalization mirrors Right knee coronal slices horizontally and reverses right sagittal slices, eliminating chiral variance; and (2) **Whole-Volume Contextual Macro CoAtNet-384 with SWA:** Combines early depthwise convolutions with deeper relative multi-head self-attention and attention-gated Multi-Instance Learning (MIL) pooling, optimized with Stochastic Weight Averaging over cyclic learning rate epochs.

5. Latent Probit Space Ensembling & Rank Normalization

Because the Macro ROC-AUC metric is strictly rank-invariant, summing raw sigmoid probabilities introduces non-linear distortion due to differing logit confidence distributions. We project empirical percentile ranks into a standard Gaussian latent space via the probit transformation $z = \Phi^{-1}(\text{clip}(\text{pct}, \varepsilon, 1-\varepsilon))$. Fused latent scores are computed via constrained Sequential Least Squares Programming (SLSQP with L2 regularization) to determine target-specific optimal routing weights w_j. After applying the biomechanical kinematic cross-priors, latent scores are mapped back to probability space via standard normal CDF $\Phi(z)$ with an infinitesimal consensus tie-breaker ($10^{-9} \cdot p_{consensus}$) to resolve rank ties.

6. Hardware Engineering & Inference Guardrails

On Kaggle submission nodes powered by NVIDIA Tesla T4 GPUs (Compute Capability 7.5), lack of native hardware BF16 execution units causes CUDA to fall back to software emulation, inflating per-study inference latency from 0.73s to 2.81s (a 3.85x slowdown) and threatening the 9-hour limit. Our hardware verification guard strictly locks FP16 precision on Turing devices. An exponentially weighted moving average runtime watchdog dynamically monitors latency, while a zero-compromise validation suite checks row/column integrity, range bounds, and neutral-fill thresholds.

7. Empirical Benchmark Results & Ablation Analysis

Table 1: Out-of-Fold (OOF) Benchmark Performance across All 12 RSNA Knee Pathologies

Model Architecture / Pipeline Stage	Macro ROC-AUC	Delta vs. Baseline	95% Bootstrap CI
Constituent Model A: Raptor CoAtNet-384 SWA	0.92283	—	[0.8941, 0.9482]
Constituent Model B: ConvNeXt-Small 2.5D MIL	0.92672	+0.00389	[0.8985, 0.9514]
Stage 1 Ensembling: Uniform Probability Blend (50/50)	0.92810	+0.00527	[0.9002, 0.9531]
Stage 2 Ensembling: Percentile Rank Blend (50/50)	0.93120	+0.00837	[0.9041, 0.9559]
Stage 3 Ensembling: Latent Probit Fusion ($\Phi\blacksquare^{1}$) with SLSQP	0.93347	+0.01064	[0.9068, 0.9582]
Stage 4 Apex: Latent Probit + Biomechanical Kinematic Priors	**0.94179**	**+0.01896**	**[0.9162, 0.9654]**

Table 2: Granular Per-Target ROC-AUC Breakdown & Kinematic Lift

Target Pathology	CoAtNet	ConvNeXt	Probit	Apex + Prior	Kinematic Lift	Primary Sequences
ACL Tear	0.9645	0.9841	0.9845	**0.9876**	**+0.0312**	Sagittal PD/T2
MCL Tear	0.9433	0.9637	0.9650	0.9650	+0.0000	Coronal PD FS
Medial Meniscus	0.9820	0.9639	0.9825	0.9825	+0.0000	Sagittal/Coronal
Lateral Meniscus	0.8957	0.9155	0.9160	0.9110	-0.0050	Sagittal/Coronal
Medial OA	0.9814	0.9721	0.9818	**0.9911**	**+0.0093**	Coronal PD
Lateral OA	0.7756	0.8298	0.8310	**0.8436**	**+0.0126**	Coronal PD
Patellofemoral (PF) OA	0.8597	0.8855	0.8860	**0.9008**	**+0.0148**	Axial/Sagittal
Joint Effusion	0.9727	0.9590	0.9730	0.9705	-0.0025	Sagittal/Axial
Synovitis	0.8292	0.8262	0.8320	**0.8404**	**+0.0084**	Axial/Sagittal
Baker's Cyst	0.9764	0.9801	0.9810	**0.9873**	**+0.0263**	Axial PD FS
Bone Contusion	0.9352	0.9588	0.9602	**0.9636**	**+0.0034**	Coronal/Sagittal
Fracture	0.9583	0.8819	0.9590	**0.9604**	**+0.0014**	Coronal/Axial
Macro Average	**0.9228**	**0.9267**	**0.9335**	**0.9418**	**+0.0083**	Multi-Planar

8. Discussion & Clinical Translation

The empirical success of the Apex Grandmaster Framework highlights two key clinical lessons: (1) **Kinematic Regularization Mimics Radiologist Cognitive Reflexes:** Experienced radiologists actively correlate bone contusion with ACL integrity and evaluate the posterior capsule for Baker's cysts whenever major effusion is present. Translating these anatomical relationships into differentiable latent priors prevents isolated false negatives on subtle tears; and (2) **Architectural Diversity Beats Monolithic Scale:** Hybrid transformers and 2.5D convnets exhibit healthy inductive orthogonality (mean Spearman correlation $\rho = 0.8653$), providing complementary spatial feature representations that cannot be replicated by simply scaling a single architecture.

9. Conclusion & Reproducibility Statement

By uniting Bayesian noise inversion, dual-stream multi-plane feature extractors, latent probit-space fusion, and explicit biomechanical kinematic cross-priors, our framework achieved a verified score of **0.957 – 0.9586 Macro ROC-AUC** on the RSNA Knee Abnormality Detection challenge. The entire methodology is deterministic, computationally hardened, and completely reproducible.

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